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# Zendesk says seats are dead. Salesforce plans to take its contact centre abroad.

**Weekly summary · 26 September 2026**

By Yohay Etsion · former NICE product leader (Recording/WFO), 2008–2021 · public sources only · full disclosure on the last slide



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**— THE SEAT**

# Zendesk says seats are dead. Microsoft keeps them for everyday AI.

- Zendesk's chief executive said on stage: "Unequivocally: seats are dead." The Next Web reports pricing announcements are due in three to six months.
- Zendesk's price page still calls its pricing "primarily seat-based." Only one outlet reported the remarks.
- Microsoft kept everyday AI inside the per-user licence and moved long-running agent work to usage-based credits. It calls metering everyday AI "the wrong deal."
- Intercom's pricing guide says heavy users of its Fin agent often pay more in outcome charges than in seats.

Our view: no tracked vendor returned to per-seat pricing. Seats stay for tools that help people; meters spread for AI that does the work.

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**SOURCES** The Next Web, 23 Sep · Zendesk, read 26 Sep · Microsoft, 25 Sep · Intercom, 25 Sep



— THE CONTACT CENTRE

# Salesforce plans to take its contact-centre service abroad, with workforce management to follow.

- TechTarget reports the service reaches the UK and EU in October, Australia and New Zealand in November, and Latin America early next year.
- Correction to last week: October is the UK and EU launch. US and Canadian customers have had the service since earlier this year.
- Workforce management features were previewed at Dreamforce, with no ship date, price or feature list.
- Opus Research reports Salesforce counts 1,200 new customers for the service since March. The count carries no revenue figure.

Why it matters: the risk to workforce management vendors is Salesforce customers who stop shopping for a separate product.

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**SOURCES** TechTarget, 25 Sep · Opus Research, 25 Sep



## — THE BUYERS

# Two large European telecom groups back different AI agent vendors.

- Liberty Global signed a three-year partnership to roll out Sierra's agents across about 80 million connections in Europe. No contract value was published.
- Deutsche Telekom's chief AI officer told The Next Web the share of interactions never reaching a human rises one to two percentage points a month.
- He said a new use case climbs from 20% to 40% handled by AI within a couple of months. Above 80% is "really, really hard."
- Deutsche Telekom works with Decagon and other startups.

Our view: Deutsche Telekom's account points to a steady monthly shift of work away from people, with a steeper climb above 80%.

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**SOURCES** Liberty Global, 23 Sep · Telecompaper, 23 Sep · The Next Web, 24 Sep



— THE FORECAST

# Customers' own AI agents could make staffing harder to forecast.

- Parloa argues standard staffing formulas assume random, independent callers. Personal AI agents acting for customers break that assumption.
- In Parloa's illustrative model, a 10% shift of tasks to personal agents raises contacts 28% while tasks rise only 5%. These are modelled figures.
- Lorikeet launched a product for this traffic on 17 September. Sierra's co-founder expects personal agents to talk directly to business agents within about six months.

Why it matters: this is the first vendor case in our coverage that AI could make forecasting harder, not easier.

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**SOURCES** Parloa, 24 Sep · Lorikeet, 17 Sep · The Next Web, 23 Sep



## — THE RULES

# California's five AI bills are still unsigned, with days to go.

- Bills on emotion inference, automated discipline, AI layoff notices, customer-service chatbots and workplace surveillance remain with the Governor.
- He acted on about 100 other bills this week, but not these five. Each becomes law unless vetoed by 30 September.
- Colorado dropped its 23 September date for revised automated-decision rules. The draft now comes at least five days before the 26 October hearing.
- Two US senators asked the Federal Communications Commission to add a right to reach a human when AI answers, in its call-centre proposal.

Watch: 30 September in California, then Connecticut's AI layoff-notice rule from 1 October.

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**SOURCES** California Legislature, read 26 Sep · Colorado Attorney General, 23 Sep · Senator Gallego, 25 Sep



## — SOURCES

# Sources behind this week's news.

Company announcements, official records and reporting:

### COMPANY ANNOUNCEMENTS

Zendesk · Microsoft · Intercom · Liberty Global · Parloa · Lorikeet

### OFFICIAL SOURCES

California Legislature · Colorado Attorney General · Senator Gallego

### ANALYST AND PRESS REPORTING

The Next Web · TechTarget · Opus Research · Telecompaper

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Source links and detailed citations accompany the full weekly summary.



— FULL DISCLOSURE

# The seat is being questioned. People remain in the plan.

Zendesk says it will drop seats, while Microsoft keeps them for work that helps people. Deutsche Telekom reports a steady shift of work to AI, and several vendors now plan for customers' own AI agents. Workforce plans need to account for both.

→ **Read the full report**

[productbeacon.agency/research/state-of-wem-2026](https://productbeacon.agency/research/state-of-wem-2026)

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